A Chronology of Chinese History and Corresponding Historical Developments in the Indian Subcontinent

The Xia dynasty (2070?–1600 BCE): What is known about this first dynasty in China is partly from legend and partly from historical accounts. It is said that the first king of the dynasty was the legendary hero Yu, credited with saving the people from a catastrophic flood of the Yellow River by building dykes and channels. Other accounts say that the first king of the dynasty was Yu's son, known as Qi. The Xia kingdom may have comprised the region between the Yellow and Yangzi rivers in their middle and lower reaches. The Xi were defeated by the Shang around 1600 BCE .

This period corresponds to the Indus Valley civilization in the Indian subcontinent. There may have been a script, possibly the symbols inscribed on the Indus Valley seals, but they are as yet undeciphered.

The Shang dynasty (1600–1046 BCE): This is the first Chinese dynasty for which there is both documentary and archaeological evidence. The Shang ruled over the north China plains. The Chinese system of writing – consisting of ideograms – began to develop in this era. Ritual vessels in bronze began to be cast during this period.

This would be the Vedic period in India, with Sanskrit as the classical language. But there is no evidence of its having had a script at this stage.

The Zhou dynasty (1046–256 BCE): This period may be divided into the Western Zhou (1046–771 BCE) and the Spring and Autumn (770–476 BCE) periods, the latter being a period of weakening Zhou rule and fragmentation. The Zhou dynasty is associated with the emergence of a distinctive Chinese polity and culture. Originally, the Zhou were tributaries to the Shang. The great Chinese philosophers Confucius and Laozi were active during the Spring and Autumn period.